

Activity 4: Plan a Singapore–Japan Distribution Partnership

Course TGS-2023020567 · K2 · K3 · A2 · A3

Objective

Adapt process, communication and team roles for a cross-cultural distribution negotiation without relying on stereotypes.

Real-world use-case basis

Real-world use case: international distribution negotiations may differ in communication, consensus, pacing, hierarchy and relationship-building. Individual behaviour must be verified rather than inferred from nationality.

Scenario

Merlion Nutrition wants a three-year Japanese distribution agreement. The prospective distributor has requested a senior executive meeting before discussing price. Merlion's founder prefers fast decisions; the distributor has circulated technical questions to several departments and has not named the final approver.

Primary source

<https://www.pon.harvard.edu/daily/negotiation-skills-daily/types-of-negotiation-skills/>

Training assumptions

- Merlion can allocate one senior sponsor and one bilingual adviser.
- Product registration will take an estimated four to six months.
- The distributor seeks exclusivity but has not committed to minimum annual volume.
- Both parties agree that all binding terms will be confirmed in English and Japanese versions reviewed by counsel.

Questions

1. Which cultural observations are facts, and which are hypotheses to test?
2. What respectful process questions should clarify authority and consensus?
3. How should the agenda balance relationship-building and commercial progress?
4. What safeguards prevent ambiguity across language versions?

Expected output

A culturally adaptive negotiation plan that clearly separates verified facts from hypotheses.

Acceptance test

The plan contains at least five verification questions, a clear authority path and no unsupported statement that treats culture as destiny.